

It

is the season of plenty in Kashmir. Shimmering gold fields of paddy, ripe for harvest, interspersed with neat rows of saffron corms. Apple orchards laden with fruit, along the highway to Pulwama district, 50 km from Srinagar. A tapestry ringed by impassive grey Himalayan massifs and a sparkling blue sky with tufts of pristine white clouds floating by. It is not just Nature that is holding out hope and promise in the Valley. The wind of democratic and political change is currently sweeping across Jammu and Kashmir (J&K), where assembly polls are being held after a hiatus of 10 long years. The election for the 90 assembly seats—43 in Jammu and 47 in Kashmir—is being held in three phases from September 18 to October 1. The results will be out on October 8, alongside those of Haryana.

In Tral, hometown of Burhan Wani, the separatist Hizbul Mujahideen chief who died young, bullets and blood will no longer determine the future, the ballot box and barnstorming politicians will. Wani's death in a firefight with security forces in 2016 had sparked off a fierce round of protests that left 90 civilians dead. Now, a much-mellowed Mehbooba Mufti, who had presided over that disturbing period as chief minister of the erstwhile state till the fall of her government in 2018, is holding a rally at Tral's main bus station that is crammed with white taxis honking for passengers. Mehbooba is president of the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP), which had entered into an alliance with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) following the 2014 assembly election, only to end in a bitter parting of ways four years later.

At her meeting in Tral, machine gun-toting government security forces are all around, including on the rooftop of the Shahi Darbar dhaba that overlooks the venue. In addition to the bullet-proof riot control truck stationed behind the podium, personnel equipped with metal detectors thoroughly frisk everyone who wants to attend the meeting. Pointing to the columns of concertina wires that cordon off the meeting ground and the armed guards around, Mehbooba says, "So many security measures mean that the Kashmir issue remains a high priority and needs urgent resolution, besides issues such as high unemployment, inflation, drug addiction and environmental degradation."

WHY THIS ELECTION IS SIGNIFICANT

"This election," Omar Abdullah, former chief minister and vice-president of the J&K National Conference (NC), says, "has come after much kicking and screaming on the part of the central government, which didn't want to hold it and did so only after the Supreme Court ordered that they be completed before the 30th of September." Even so, it will be a defining election for more than one reason. For one, it is the first assembly poll after the Modi government revoked Article 370 on August 5, 2019, de-